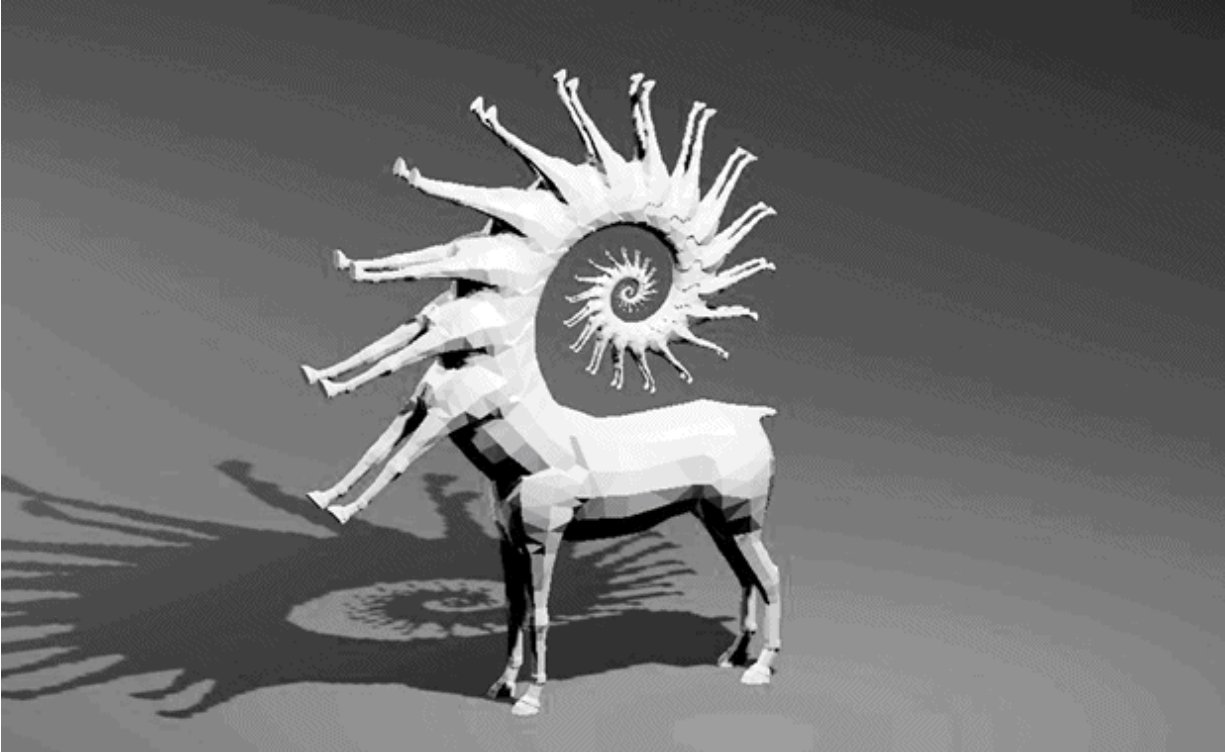




*Figure 1-3: The recursive centaur. Image by Joseph Parker.*

Based on these jokes, you might conclude that recursion is a sort of meta, self-referencing, dream-within-a-dream, infinite mirror-into-mirror sort of thing. Let's establish a concrete definition: a *recursive* thing is something whose definition includes itself. That is, it has a self-referential definition.

The Sierpiński triangle in [Figure 1-4](#) is defined as an equilateral triangle with an upside-down triangle in the middle that forms three new equilateral triangles, each of which contains a Sierpiński triangle. The definition of Sierpiński triangles includes Sierpiński triangles.